

ISBA 2411 - Midterm Mini-Project Rubric

300 points — worth 30% of the course grade. A take-home mini-project: the **same set project and provided data for everyone.**

Collaboration: tied to the final-project teams. Students **may work with their project team** (approach, debugging, comparing results) but **each person submits their own files** in their own words. Identical/copy-pasted submissions are not independent work.

Deliverables (uploaded to Camino): (1) a **PDF of the completed notebook**, (2) a **link to the student's Colab notebook**, and (3) a **write-up** — either in the notebook (Part 5) or a separate document.

Scope: uses only methods covered **through Week 6** - text classification, retrieval / semantic search, topic modeling, embeddings, or a small neural net.

Pretrained models are tools, not projects. Students may *call* a pretrained transformer-based embedding model (e.g. `sentence-transformers`) as a feature extractor, since Lecture 11 covers what it is doing. They may **not** fine-tune or train a transformer, use an LLM to generate the predictions, or build a RAG pipeline - those come after the midterm.

AI assistants are permitted **with disclosure**: students state which tools they used and for what. The Analysis sections are written against each student's own run (their confusion matrix, their misclassified rows), which an assistant cannot supply.

This is the smaller sibling of the Milestone / Final Project rubric: same three criteria and the same 5-level scale, scaled down for a mini-project.

Criteria

Criterion	Points	What it measures
Execution	150	Applies an appropriate Week-1-to-6 method to the provided task and produces a correct, working result.
Analysis & Insight	100	Interprets the result: what was found and why, with at least one concrete observation about where the method works or fails.

Criterion	Points	What it measures
Communication	50	Clear, organized write-up or demo; states the approach and the results plainly.
Total	300	

Levels

Each criterion is scored on the same five levels (points shown for each criterion).

Execution — 150 pts

- **5 · Exceptional (150)** - Sound, well-chosen method; correct and complete result within the time frame.
- **4 · Strong (120)** - Solid method; result mostly correct with minor gaps.
- **3 · Adequate (90)** - Reasonable method; runs but with notable gaps.
- **2 · Developing (60)** - Weak or partial method; result incomplete or partly incorrect.
- **1 · Weak (30)** - Method unsound or result missing / non-functional.

Analysis & Insight — 100 pts

- **5 · Exceptional (100)** - Insightful read of the results; clearly explains why the method behaved as it did.
- **4 · Strong (80)** - Good interpretation; minor gaps in reasoning.
- **3 · Adequate (60)** - Basic interpretation; results reported with limited insight.
- **2 · Developing (40)** - Minimal interpretation beyond raw output.
- **1 · Weak (20)** - No meaningful analysis or interpretation.

Communication — 50 pts

- **5 · Exceptional (50)** - Clear, well-organized; approach and results easy to follow.
- **4 · Strong (40)** - Clear and organized; minor rough spots.
- **3 · Adequate (30)** - Generally clear.
- **2 · Developing (20)** - Disorganized or unclear in places.
- **1 · Weak (10)** - Unclear or disorganized.

Mirrors the ISBA 2411 Milestone Assignment Rubric (Execution / Analysis & Insight / Communication), scaled to 300 points — 30% of the course grade.